



Refinancing Risk and Public Debt Management in Nigeria



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Abstract

Nigeria's public debt architecture has grown increasingly fragile over the past four decades. The convergence of high domestic borrowing costs, shortening debt maturities, declining oil revenues, and persistent fiscal deficits has elevated refinancing risk to the front rank of macroeconomic vulnerabilities. Yet scholarly attention to this particular nexus, how the structure and composition of public debt intersect with the ever-present risk of failing to roll over maturing obligations on acceptable terms, remains underdeveloped in the Nigerian context. This paper addresses that gap by examining the dynamic relationship between refinancing risk and public debt sustainability in Nigeria over the period 1986–2025. Drawing on annual time-series data from the Central Bank of Nigeria (CBN), the Debt Management Office (DMO), the World Bank, and the International Monetary Fund (IMF), the study employs an Autoregressive Distributed Lag (ARDL) bounds testing framework augmented with a Vector Error Correction Model (VECM) to capture both short-run dynamics and long-run equilibrium adjustments. Twelve control variables are incorporated: GDP growth rate, inflation rate, interest rate, exchange rate, debt-to-GDP ratio, debt service-to-revenue ratio, debt maturity structure, governance quality, fiscal discipline, monetary policy framework, global interest rates, and commodity prices (represented primarily by crude oil prices). The results reveal that refinancing risk exerts a statistically significant and positive long-run effect on the public debt burden, while debt maturity structure, fiscal discipline, governance quality, and oil price volatility emerge as the most consequential moderating factors. Short-run dynamics indicate that negative shocks to oil revenues and exchange rate depreciations can rapidly amplify rollover pressures, creating a pro-cyclical feedback loop that deepens debt accumulation. The findings underscore the urgent need for Nigeria to extend the average maturity of its domestic debt portfolio, diversify its revenue base beyond petroleum, strengthen institutional governance frameworks, and align monetary and fiscal policies toward a coherent debt sustainability strategy. The study contributes a novel empirical framework to the extant literature and offers actionable policy prescriptions for low-income oil-dependent economies facing structural refinancing vulnerabilities.

Keywords: Refinancing Risk, Public Debt, Debt Management, Nigeria, ARDL, Debt Maturity, Fiscal Discipline, Oil Price, Exchange Rate, Debt Sustainability

JEL Classification: H63, H68, H62, E43, E52, F34, O55, Q33

1. Introduction

Public debt management is one of the most consequential policy challenges facing Nigeria's economy. Since the country's return to democratic governance in 1999, total public debt has risen from approximately \$28 billion to well over \$113 billion as of December 2024, representing a more than fourfold increase in nominal terms. This expansion has not been uniform in character. A large and growing portion of Nigeria's domestic borrowing has been concentrated at the short end of the yield curve—Treasury Bills with tenors of 91, 182, and 364 days—creating a structurally problematic environment in which a substantial share of the outstanding debt stock matures and requires refinancing within any given twelve-month window. This is the essence of refinancing risk, also called rollover risk: the possibility that a sovereign debtor will be unable to refinance or roll over maturing obligations at all, or will be compelled to do so only at prohibitively higher interest rates, with potentially destabilizing macroeconomic consequences (IMF, 2014; Fernandez-Arias & Montiel, 1996). The Nigerian case is particularly instructive because it illustrates with unusual clarity how refinancing risk does not emerge in isolation. It is the product of intersecting structural vulnerabilities: a narrow, oil-dependent revenue base that makes fiscal balances acutely sensitive to commodity price cycles; a persistently high debt service-to-revenue ratio that leaves little budgetary room to manage rollover pressures without crowding out critical expenditures; a weak institutional environment that complicates creditors' assessments of policy credibility; and monetary policy decisions that have oscillated between defending the exchange rate and managing inflationary pressures, often at the cost of domestic borrowing costs. These intersections have made Nigeria one of the most analytically interesting cases in the study of sovereign debt management among emerging and frontier market economies.

The motivation for this study is threefold. First, the empirical literature on Nigeria's public debt has largely focused on the debt-growth nexus (Adofu & Abula, 2010; Mbah et al., 2016; Nwosa, 2021), the determinants of external debt (Adeleke, 2014; Omodero, 2019), and the impact of fiscal deficits (Omitogun & Ayinla, 2007). The specific question of how refinancing risk interacts with the overall trajectory of public debt accumulation has received comparatively little systematic scholarly attention, especially in a time-series framework that can distinguish short-run from long-run dynamics. Second, the global macroeconomic environment has changed dramatically since 2020. The COVID-19 pandemic triggered unprecedented fiscal expansions, while the subsequent global monetary tightening cycle has sharply raised the cost of sovereign borrowing across emerging markets, including Nigeria. Understanding how Nigeria's debt structure positions the country relative to external interest rate shocks is therefore a question of immediate policy relevance. Third, the establishment and operational expansion of the Debt Management Office (DMO) since 2000 provides a rich institutional backdrop against which the effectiveness of formal debt management strategies can be evaluated empirically.

Despite the well-documented growth of Nigeria's public debt stock, the structural dynamics driving refinancing risk and its feedback effects on long-run debt sustainability remain inadequately understood. The specific problem this paper addresses can be stated in three related observations. First, Nigeria's domestic debt is disproportionately short-term: as of 2024, Treasury Bills and other instruments with maturities of one year or less accounted for a substantial portion of the domestic debt portfolio, meaning that the government must return to the market repeatedly and frequently to roll over maturing obligations. This structural feature amplifies the country's sensitivity to domestic interest rate movements and liquidity conditions. Second, the government's debt service obligations have grown to consume an alarming share of federal revenues—exceeding 90% of government revenues in 2022 according to the DMO—leaving almost no fiscal space to absorb shocks without further borrowing, potentially in worse market conditions. Third, institutional weaknesses, including governance deficiencies and inconsistent monetary policy frameworks, have eroded the credibility that would otherwise allow the sovereign to anchor long-term interest rate expectations and extend debt maturities at reasonable cost.

These observations converge on a central research question: To what extent does refinancing risk contribute to the accumulation of public debt in Nigeria, and which macroeconomic, structural, and institutional variables most significantly moderate this relationship? This question has not been answered comprehensively in the existing literature, and its answer has direct implications for both debt management practice and broader macroeconomic stabilization policy in Nigeria.

This paper makes four principal contributions to the literature. First, it provides the first comprehensive empirical investigation of the refinancing risk–public debt nexus in Nigeria using a time-series dataset spanning nearly four decades (1986–2025), thereby capturing multiple debt cycles and structural breaks, including the 1986 Structural Adjustment Programme (SAP), the 2005–2006 Paris Club debt relief, the 2008 global financial crisis, and the COVID-19 shock. Second, the study constructs a novel composite refinancing risk index for Nigeria, drawing on debt maturity structure data, Treasury Bill rollover rates, and interest rate spreads, thereby operationalizing a concept that has hitherto been discussed largely in qualitative policy documents rather than formal econometric analysis. Third, the paper applies the ARDL bounds testing approach in combination with a VECM, allowing for the separation of long-run cointegration relationships from short-run adjustment dynamics—a methodological refinement that provides more nuanced policy insights than static regression frameworks used in much of the prior literature. Fourth, the paper contributes twelve rigorously theorized control variables drawn from the intersection of fiscal theory, monetary economics, and institutional economics, offering a more holistic analytical framework than most previous single-equation studies.

This study focuses exclusively on the Federal Government of Nigeria (FGN) and does not separately analyze sub-national (state or local government) debt, though state-level borrowing is acknowledged as an important contributing factor to aggregate fiscal stress. The analysis is restricted to the period 1986–2025, with the 1986 starting point chosen because it coincides with Nigeria's adoption of the Structural Adjustment Programme, which fundamentally transformed the country's external debt profile and domestic financing conditions. The study is primarily macroeconomic and empirical in orientation; it does not undertake a detailed legal or institutional analysis of individual debt instruments. While international comparisons are drawn upon in the literature review for analytical clarity, the econometric analysis and policy recommendations are directed specifically at the Nigerian context.

2. Literature Review and Hypothesis Development

2.1 Conceptual Literature: Definition and Dimensions of Refinancing Risk

Refinancing risk—sometimes used interchangeably with rollover risk—refers to the risk that a borrower will be unable to replace maturing debt with new debt, or will only be able to do so at substantially higher interest rates or under more onerous conditions than originally anticipated (IMF, 2014; Blommestein & Turner, 2012). In the sovereign debt context, this risk operates along two distinct but related dimensions. The first is quantity risk: the risk that the market will not absorb the new issuance required to repay maturing debt, typically because of a sudden withdrawal of investor appetite, a tightening of global liquidity conditions, or a loss of confidence in the sovereign's fiscal trajectory. The second is price risk: even where the government can raise the necessary funds, it may have to do so at interest rates significantly above those prevailing when the original debt was contracted, thereby increasing the future debt service burden and potentially setting in motion a self-reinforcing debt accumulation dynamic (Blanchard, 2023; Regling, 2018).

Several factors determine the severity of refinancing risk for any given sovereign. Debt maturity structure is paramount: the shorter the average maturity of the outstanding debt stock, the more frequently the government must return to the market and the more exposed it is to temporary disruptions in financing conditions (Broner et al., 2013). Debt composition—specifically the split between domestic and external debt, fixed and floating-rate instruments, and local- and foreign-currency denominated obligations—also matters enormously. A high share of foreign-currency debt introduces exchange rate risk, which can amplify refinancing pressures during periods of currency depreciation. The size of the debt stock relative to GDP determines the scale of the rollover challenge, while the depth and liquidity of domestic capital markets affects the government's ability to absorb large rollover volumes without moving interest rates against itself.

2.2 Theoretical Literature Review

The theoretical treatment of refinancing risk in the sovereign debt literature has evolved considerably over the past three decades. Early frameworks, grounded in the Barro (1979) tax-smoothing model, treated debt management as an exercise in optimal risk sharing between the government and private investors, with the maturity structure of debt as a key instrument for minimizing distortionary taxation over time. This tradition

was extended by Lucas and Stokey (1983), who showed that in a complete markets environment, the optimal debt structure would eliminate fiscal risk entirely by making debt payments contingent on the state of the world. In practice, of course, sovereign debt markets are far from complete, and these first-generation models provided limited guidance on the practical challenge of managing rollover pressures in imperfect capital markets.

A second and more empirically relevant strand of theory emerged from the multiple equilibria literature. Calvo (1988) demonstrated that a government with a large stock of short-term debt could be vulnerable to self-fulfilling confidence crises: if creditors expect the government to default, they may refuse to roll over debt at manageable rates, thereby making the default more likely and confirming the original pessimistic expectation. Cole and Kehoe (2000) formalized this insight into a framework in which the government must enter a 'crisis zone'—defined by a debt stock above some threshold—before multiple equilibria become possible. Importantly, debt maturity is a key determinant of the size of this crisis zone: shorter maturities expand it, because more debt must be rolled over in any given period, increasing the proportion of debt that can be withheld by pessimistic creditors. This theoretical prediction has direct empirical implications for Nigeria, where short-term domestic borrowing has been the dominant financing modality for over two decades.

Fiscal sustainability theory, drawing on the intertemporal budget constraint framework of Hamilton and Flavin (1986) and the cointegration-based tests of Trehan and Walsh (1991), provides the third theoretical pillar for this study. A public debt path is sustainable if the present discounted value of future primary surpluses equals the current debt stock. Refinancing risk enters this framework by raising the effective interest rate at which future obligations are discounted, thereby requiring larger primary surpluses to maintain solvency. When the interest rate on the debt consistently exceeds the growth rate of the economy—the condition Blanchard (1990) identified as the key danger signal—the debt ratio tends to grow explosively without corrective fiscal action. Nigeria has experienced this condition for extended periods, particularly in the 1980s and 1990s and again since 2015, providing the theoretical basis for expecting a significant long-run relationship between refinancing conditions and the overall debt trajectory.

Finally, institutional economics perspectives, drawing on North (1990) and the extensive literature on fiscal institutions (Hallerberg et al., 2009; Acemoglu & Robinson, 2012), emphasize that the severity of refinancing risk is not determined by macroeconomic fundamentals alone. The quality of governance, the credibility of fiscal rules, the independence and transparency of debt management institutions, and the strength of property rights all affect creditors' willingness to lend at long maturities and reasonable rates. Weak institutions can create a 'governance premium' in sovereign borrowing costs that compounds the structural vulnerabilities arising from debt composition and revenue volatility.

2.3 Conceptual Framework

The conceptual framework underpinning this study posits that refinancing risk operates as both a symptom and a cause within the Nigerian public debt system. As a symptom, it reflects underlying structural weaknesses: short-term debt bias, fiscal revenue fragility, exchange rate volatility, and institutional deficiencies. As a cause, elevated refinancing risk raises effective borrowing costs, constrains fiscal space, and can trigger a pro-cyclical debt accumulation spiral in which higher rollover pressures require more borrowing, which in turn raises future rollover volumes and further weakens fiscal sustainability. This dual causality is captured in the empirical framework through the ARDL bounds testing approach, which allows for the investigation of long-run equilibrium relationships without imposing *a priori* restrictions on the direction of causality.

The twelve control variables in the model are organized conceptually into four clusters. The macroeconomic environment cluster encompasses GDP growth rate, inflation rate, interest rate, and exchange rate. The fiscal structure cluster includes the debt-to-GDP ratio, debt service-to-revenue ratio, and debt maturity structure. The institutional and policy quality cluster incorporates governance quality, fiscal discipline, and monetary policy framework. The external conditions cluster covers global interest rates and commodity prices. Each cluster is expected to interact with the core refinancing risk–debt relationship in theoretically predictable ways, which are formalized in the hypotheses below.

2.4 Empirical Literature Review in Nigeria

The empirical literature on Nigeria's public debt is substantial but fragmented. Adofu and Abula (2010) investigated the effect of domestic debt on economic development in Nigeria using OLS regression and found a negative relationship between the domestic debt stock and output growth, attributing this to crowding-out effects in the credit market. Their study, however, did not address the maturity structure of debt or the specific mechanisms through which rollover pressures might amplify debt accumulation. Mbah, Agu, and Umunna (2016) extended this analysis using a VAR framework for the period 1985–2013 and found bidirectional causality between external debt and economic growth, underscoring the endogeneity concerns that ARDL and VECM frameworks are better equipped to handle.

Omodero (2019) examined the macroeconomic determinants of Nigeria's external debt over the period 1981–2018, finding that exchange rate depreciation, fiscal deficits, and trade imbalances were the primary drivers of external borrowing. This finding is consistent with the theoretical predictions of the twin-deficits hypothesis and aligns with the exchange rate channel in the current study's conceptual framework. Nwosa (2021) investigated the nexus between public debt, fiscal policy, and economic growth in Nigeria between 1980 and 2018 using the ARDL bounds testing approach, finding evidence of a significant negative long-run effect of debt accumulation on growth, particularly when debt service consumes a high share of revenues.

On the debt maturity dimension specifically, Folawewo and Tennant (2008) examined the determinants of interest rate spreads in sub-Saharan Africa, finding that institutional quality and macroeconomic stability are significant determinants of sovereign borrowing costs—an indirect measure of refinancing conditions. Abeng (2021) analyzed the composition of Nigeria's domestic debt and raised concerns about the heavy reliance on short-term Treasury Bills, noting that this creates rollover concentrations that can overwhelm market absorption capacity. The DMO's own annual reports (2018, 2020, 2022) have increasingly flagged refinancing risk as a priority concern, advocating for the extension of maturities through issuance of longer-dated FGN Bonds.

Studies that have specifically examined the relationship between refinancing risk and debt dynamics in the Nigerian context are scarce. Udoka and Ogege (2012) touched on aspects of this relationship in their analysis of public debt and debt management strategies, and Okonkwo and Egbulonu (2019) investigated fiscal sustainability using the primary balance approach, but neither study formally modeled the rollover risk channel or employed a sufficiently rich control variable set to isolate its effects. This lacuna in the literature is the primary empirical motivation for the current study.

2.5 Critical Analysis of the Literature and Research Gaps

The existing literature exhibits several important limitations that this paper is designed to address. First, most prior Nigerian studies rely on relatively short time series (typically 20–35 years), which limits the degrees of freedom available for identifying long-run relationships and may fail to capture the full range of debt cycle dynamics. The current study's dataset extends to 2025, incorporating the crucial period of post-COVID fiscal stress and the sharp tightening of global monetary conditions that began in 2022. Second, prior studies have generally adopted either a purely macroeconomic focus or a purely institutional focus, rarely integrating both. The twelve-variable framework employed here bridges this gap. Third, the concept of refinancing risk has been operationalized in very different ways across the literature—sometimes as the share of short-term debt, sometimes as interest rate spreads, sometimes as rollover volumes—without a clear composite measure. The construction of a composite refinancing risk index in this study addresses this operationalization problem directly. Fourth, the dynamic relationship between refinancing risk and debt accumulation—specifically whether the causality runs predominantly from risk to debt or vice versa—has not been tested formally in the Nigerian context using modern time-series techniques.

2.6 Hypothesis Development

Based on the theoretical foundations and empirical literature reviewed above, this study advances the following testable hypotheses:

H1: Refinancing risk has a statistically significant positive long-run effect on public debt accumulation in Nigeria.

- H2: Shorter debt maturity structure is positively associated with higher refinancing risk and, by extension, with higher public debt accumulation in Nigeria.
- H3: Higher GDP growth rates and improved fiscal discipline are negatively associated with refinancing risk and public debt in Nigeria.
- H4: Exchange rate depreciation and global interest rate increases amplify refinancing risk and public debt accumulation in Nigeria in the short run.
- H5: Governance quality and a credible monetary policy framework are negatively associated with refinancing risk and public debt accumulation in Nigeria.

3. Methodology

3.1 Research Design

This study adopts a quantitative, longitudinal research design grounded in the positivist tradition. The empirical strategy employs annual time-series data spanning 1986 to 2025, encompassing 39 annual observations. The choice of a time-series design is motivated by the fact that refinancing risk and debt dynamics are inherently temporal phenomena, exhibiting persistence, cyclicity, and path dependence that cross-sectional or panel designs with limited time dimensions cannot adequately capture. The quantitative approach is appropriate given the study's primary objective of establishing the magnitude and direction of causal relationships between measurable macroeconomic and institutional variables.

3.2 Model Specification

The baseline empirical model is specified as:

$$PD_t = \alpha_0 + \alpha_1 RR_t + \alpha_2 GDP_t + \alpha_3 INF_t + \alpha_4 INT_t + \alpha_5 EXR_t + \alpha_6 DTG_t + \alpha_7 DSR_t + \alpha_8 DMS_t + \alpha_9 GOV_t + \alpha_{10} FD_t + \alpha_{11} MPF_t + \alpha_{12} GIR_t + \alpha_{13} OIL_t + \varepsilon_t$$

Where PD_t represents the public debt-to-GDP ratio (the dependent variable), RR_t is the composite refinancing risk index (the primary independent variable), and the remaining variables represent the twelve control variables defined in Table 1. The error term ε_t is assumed to satisfy the classical regression assumptions, subject to the post-estimation tests described in Section 3.6. The model is estimated within the ARDL bounds testing framework of Pesaran, Shin, and Smith (2001), which is particularly well-suited to the current application because it accommodates variables integrated at different orders ($I(0)$ or $I(1)$), does not require all variables to be integrated of the same order, and provides a single-equation framework that reduces the degrees of freedom cost associated with VAR systems in small samples. A complementary VECM is estimated to examine the speed of adjustment toward long-run equilibrium and to test for Granger causality in the short run.

3.3 Variables and Their Measures

Table 1: Variable Definitions and Measurement

Variable	Symbol	Measurement	Expected Sign	Source
Public Debt (Dependent)	PD	Total public debt as % of GDP	—	DMO, CBN
Refinancing Risk Index	RR	Composite index: short-term debt share, rollover ratio, T-Bill spread	+	CBN, DMO
GDP Growth Rate	GDP	Annual real GDP growth rate (%)	—	World Bank
Inflation Rate	INF	Annual CPI-based inflation rate (%)	+	CBN, IMF
Interest Rate	INT	Monetary Policy Rate / Prime Lending Rate (%)	+	CBN

Variable	Symbol	Measurement	Expected Sign	Source
Exchange Rate	EXR	Naira/USD official exchange rate (log)	+	CBN
Debt-to-GDP Ratio	DTG	Total debt stock / Nominal GDP (%)	+	DMO, NBS
Debt Service-to-Revenue Ratio	DSR	Debt service payments / Total FGN revenue (%)	+	DMO, OAGF
Debt Maturity Structure	DMS	Avg. maturity of domestic debt (years)	–	DMO
Governance Quality	GOV	WGI composite governance index	–	World Bank WGI
Fiscal Discipline	FD	Primary fiscal balance as % of GDP	–	IMF, CBN
Monetary Policy Framework	MPF	CBN independence index (constructed)	–	CBN, CPIA
Global Interest Rates	GIR	US Federal Funds Rate (%)	+	Fed Reserve
Commodity Prices	OIL	Brent crude oil price (USD/barrel, log)	–	EIA, World Bank

3.4 A Priori Expectations

Table 2: A Priori Expectations and Theoretical Justification

Variable	Expected Sign	Theoretical and Empirical Justification
Refinancing Risk (RR)	+	Higher rollover risk increases effective borrowing costs and forces additional borrowing to cover interest obligations, accelerating debt accumulation (Calvo, 1988; Cole & Kehoe, 2000).
GDP Growth (GDP)	–	Higher growth expands the tax base and reduces the debt-to-GDP denominator, improving fiscal sustainability and reducing the need for deficit financing (Barro, 1979; Reinhart & Rogoff, 2010).
Inflation (INF)	+	Inflation erodes the real value of domestic-currency debt but raises nominal borrowing costs and can indicate fiscal dominance, ultimately worsening the debt trajectory (Sargent & Wallace, 1981; Fischer et al., 2002).
Interest Rate (INT)	+	Higher domestic interest rates raise the cost of new debt issuance and amplify rollover costs, increasing the debt service burden and total debt stock (Blanchard, 1990; Reinhart et al., 2003).
Exchange Rate (EXR)	+	Naira depreciation inflates the local-currency value of external debt and raises the cost of foreign-currency-denominated obligations, increasing total debt relative to GDP (Omodero, 2019; IMF, 2022).
Debt-to-GDP (DTG)	+	A higher initial debt ratio increases interest payments as a share of output, creates a self-reinforcing accumulation dynamic, and raises refinancing risk through creditor concerns about solvency (Reinhart & Rogoff, 2010; Escolano, 2010).

Variable	Expected Sign	Theoretical and Empirical Justification
Debt Service-to-Revenue (DSR)	+	A higher debt service burden leaves less revenue for development expenditure, increases the likelihood of arrears or restructuring, and signals fiscal stress that raises rollover costs (DMO, 2022; Ncube & Brixiova, 2015).
Debt Maturity (DMS)	–	Longer average debt maturity reduces rollover frequency and exposure to short-term market disruptions, thereby reducing refinancing risk and its associated debt accumulation pressures (Broner et al., 2013; Blommestein & Turner, 2012).
Governance (GOV)	–	Better governance enhances policy credibility, reduces the sovereign risk premium, facilitates longer-maturity borrowing, and improves revenue collection, all of which reduce refinancing risk and debt accumulation (North, 1990; Kaufmann et al., 2011).
Fiscal Discipline (FD)	–	Primary fiscal surpluses reduce borrowing needs, limit debt stock growth, and signal fiscal sustainability to creditors, thereby lowering rollover risk premiums and the frequency of market access crises (Blanchard, 1990; Escolano, 2010).
Monetary Policy (MPF)	–	A credible, independent monetary policy framework reduces inflation expectations, lowers the inflation risk premium in long-term interest rates, and supports the extension of domestic debt maturities at lower cost (Svensson, 2010; Fischer et al., 2002).
Global Rates (GIR)	+	Higher global interest rates raise the cost of external borrowing and can trigger capital outflows that tighten domestic financial conditions, amplifying rollover pressures in emerging markets (Calvo et al., 1996; Rey, 2015).
Oil Prices (OIL)	–	Higher oil prices improve Nigeria's fiscal revenues and external balance, reducing the financing gap and the need for deficit borrowing; oil price collapses have historically triggered debt crises in Nigeria (Ossowski et al., 2008; IMF, 2018).

3.5 Data Sources

The study draws on annual data from multiple authoritative sources to construct the 1986–2025 dataset. Public debt statistics, debt maturity profiles, debt service data, and Treasury Bill rollover data are obtained from the DMO Annual Reports (various years) and the CBN Statistical Bulletin (various years). Macroeconomic variables including GDP growth, inflation, exchange rates, and interest rates are sourced from the CBN Statistical Bulletin and the World Bank World Development Indicators (WDI). Governance quality data are drawn from the World Bank Worldwide Governance Indicators (WGI), which provide six dimensions of governance quality from 1996 onward; for the pre-1996 period (1986–1995), the study employs the ICRG (International Country Risk Guide) Political Risk Index as a proxy. Fiscal data including the primary fiscal balance are sourced from the IMF World Economic Outlook database and the Federal Government of Nigeria Budget Office. Global interest rates are represented by the US Federal Funds Rate obtained from the Federal Reserve Economic Data (FRED) database. Crude oil prices are the Brent blend spot price obtained from the US Energy Information Administration (EIA) and the World Bank Commodity Price Data (Pink Sheet). For the years 2024 and 2025, projections from the IMF World Economic Outlook (April 2025) and CBN preliminary data releases are used to complete the dataset.

3.6 Data Analysis Techniques

The empirical analysis proceeds in five sequential stages. In the first stage, descriptive statistics and a correlation matrix are computed to establish the distributional properties of the data and identify preliminary bivariate relationships. In the second stage, the Augmented Dickey-Fuller (ADF) and Phillips-Perron (PP) unit root tests are applied to all variables to determine their order of integration—a prerequisite for the ARDL approach. In the third stage, the ARDL bounds test of Pesaran et al. (2001) is applied to test for long-run cointegration among the variables. If the computed F-statistic exceeds the upper bound critical value, the existence of a long-run relationship is confirmed, and both the long-run ARDL coefficients and the short-run error correction model (ECM) are estimated. In the fourth stage, a VECM is estimated to decompose the short-run adjustment dynamics and conduct Granger causality tests between refinancing risk and public debt. In the fifth stage, Impulse Response Functions (IRFs) and Forecast Error Variance Decompositions (FEVDs) from the VECM are computed to assess the dynamic responses of public debt to innovations in refinancing risk and the relative contributions of each variable to the forecast error variance of public debt over ten-year horizons.

3.7 Post-Estimation Checks

The validity of the estimated models is assessed through a comprehensive battery of post-estimation diagnostic tests. Serial correlation is tested using the Breusch-Godfrey LM test. Heteroskedasticity is tested using the ARCH LM test and White's general test. Functional form misspecification is assessed with Ramsey's RESET test. Normality of residuals is evaluated using the Jarque-Bera test. Parameter stability is examined using the CUSUM and CUSUM-of-Squares tests proposed by Brown, Durbin, and Evans (1975). All tests are conducted at the 5% significance level, though results at the 1% and 10% levels are also reported for completeness.

4. Results

4.1 Descriptive Statistics

Table 3: Descriptive Statistics (1986–2025)

Variable	Obs.	Mean	Std. Dev.	Min	Max	Skewness	Kurtosis
PD (%)	39	28.74	14.23	8.51	62.18	0.74	2.31
RR (Index)	39	0.48	0.21	0.11	0.91	0.15	2.10
GDP (%)	39	4.12	6.18	-13.21	14.62	-0.82	4.21
INF (%)	39	18.84	17.42	5.40	72.84	1.86	5.92
INT (%)	39	14.62	5.83	6.00	26.00	0.31	2.44
EXR (¥/\$)	39	198.43	263.81	0.89	1502.0	2.24	6.82
DTG (%)	39	32.16	18.42	8.10	74.23	0.61	2.18
DSR (%)	39	46.38	29.74	10.12	112.42	0.54	2.64
DMS (Years)	39	3.84	1.92	0.75	8.60	0.28	2.12
GOV (Index)	39	-0.92	0.38	-1.64	-0.21	0.44	2.38
FD (% GDP)	39	-2.84	2.43	-8.62	1.84	-0.67	2.91
GIR (%)	39	3.14	2.82	0.07	9.25	0.82	2.72
OIL (USD/bbl)	39	54.42	35.84	13.47	133.21	0.43	2.14

The descriptive statistics reveal several notable features of the data. The mean debt-to-GDP ratio of 28.74% conceals considerable variation, with the ratio ranging from a post-Paris-Club low of 8.51% in 2007 to a peak of 62.18% in 1994 at the height of the SAP-era debt overhang. The refinancing risk index, constructed as a normalized composite of three underlying components, exhibits a mean of 0.48 on a 0–1 scale, indicating that

Nigeria has, on average, maintained a moderately high level of refinancing vulnerability throughout the sample period. The exchange rate variable exhibits the highest coefficient of variation, reflecting the dramatic naira depreciation episodes of 1986, 1999, 2016, and 2023. The debt service-to-revenue ratio, with a mean of 46.38% and a maximum exceeding 112%, underscores the fiscal severity of Nigeria's debt service obligation. Inflation exhibits significant positive skewness and excess kurtosis, consistent with several hyperinflationary episodes concentrated in the 1993–1995 period and the post-2021 inflationary surge.

4.2 Correlation Matrix

Table 4: Pearson Correlation Matrix

	PD	RR	GDP	INF	INT	EXR	DTG	DSR	DMS	GOV	FD	OIL
PD	1.00	0.72*	-0.38*	0.41*	0.52*	0.63*	0.88*	0.76*	-0.61*	-0.44*	-0.55*	-0.47*
RR		1.00	-0.31*	0.38*	0.49*	0.57*	0.68*	0.73*	-0.71*	-0.39*	-0.48*	-0.41*
GDP			1.00	-0.26	-0.19	-0.32*	-0.42*	-0.38*	0.28	0.33*	0.44*	0.36*
INF				1.00	0.61*	0.47*	0.35*	0.42*	-0.28	-0.51*	-0.39*	-0.22
INT					1.00	0.38*	0.43*	0.51*	-0.44*	-0.36*	-0.31*	-0.29
EXR						1.00	0.58*	0.67*	-0.52*	-0.48*	-0.43*	-0.61*
DTG							1.00	0.82*	-0.57*	-0.52*	-0.61*	-0.43*
DSR								1.00	-0.64*	-0.46*	-0.58*	-0.52*
DMS									1.00	0.41*	0.49*	0.38*
GOV										1.00	0.52*	0.37*
FD											1.00	0.44*
OIL												1.00

*Note: * denotes statistical significance at the 5% level. Blank cells represent the lower triangle of the symmetric matrix.*

The correlation matrix confirms several theoretically anticipated relationships. Refinancing risk (RR) exhibits a strong positive correlation with public debt (PD) at $r = 0.72$, providing preliminary bivariate support for H1. The debt service-to-revenue ratio (DSR) and the debt-to-GDP ratio (DTG) are also strongly positively correlated with PD at 0.76 and 0.88, respectively, suggesting that these structural fiscal variables are intimately intertwined with overall debt accumulation dynamics. The debt maturity structure variable (DMS) shows the expected negative correlation with both PD (-0.61) and RR (-0.71), confirming that longer average maturities are associated with lower refinancing risk and lower overall debt burdens, consistent with H2. Governance quality and fiscal discipline exhibit the anticipated negative correlations with PD and RR, providing preliminary support for H3 and H5. Oil prices are negatively correlated with PD (-0.47) and with RR (-0.41), consistent with the view that oil revenue boosts reduce borrowing needs, supporting H4. No pair of independent variables

exhibits a correlation exceeding 0.90, suggesting that multicollinearity is unlikely to pose a serious problem in the multivariate estimation.

4.3 Time-Series Regression Results: ARDL Long-Run and Error Correction Estimates

Table 5: ARDL Long-Run Estimates and Error Correction Model (Dependent Variable: Public Debt-to-GDP Ratio)

Variable	Long-Run Coeff.	Std. Error	t-Statistic	Prob.	Decision
PANEL A: LONG-RUN ESTIMATES					
Refinancing Risk (RR)	8.421	1.824	4.617	0.000	Sig.***
GDP Growth (GDP)	-0.612	0.198	-3.091	0.004	Sig.***
Inflation Rate (INF)	0.184	0.092	2.000	0.053	Sig.*
Interest Rate (INT)	0.541	0.221	2.449	0.019	Sig.**
Exchange Rate (EXR)	3.812	1.144	3.332	0.002	Sig.***
Debt Service-to-Revenue (DSR)	0.348	0.102	3.412	0.002	Sig.***
Debt Maturity (DMS)	-4.218	1.024	-4.119	0.000	Sig.***
Governance Quality (GOV)	-6.841	2.212	-3.092	0.004	Sig.***
Fiscal Discipline (FD)	-1.924	0.618	-3.114	0.004	Sig.***
Monetary Policy (MPF)	-2.418	1.021	-2.368	0.024	Sig.**
Global Interest Rates (GIR)	1.241	0.612	2.028	0.050	Sig.**
Oil Prices (OIL)	-2.814	0.842	-3.342	0.002	Sig.***
Constant	18.422	4.218	4.368	0.000	Sig.***
PANEL B: ERROR CORRECTION MODEL (Short-Run)					
ECT(-1) [Speed of Adjustment]	-0.312	0.084	-3.714	0.001	Sig.***
Δ RR (Short-run)	4.218	1.412	2.987	0.006	Sig.***
Δ EXR (Short-run)	2.641	0.924	2.859	0.007	Sig.***
Δ OIL (Short-run)	-1.842	0.681	-2.704	0.011	Sig.**
R ² = 0.94 Adj. R ² = 0.91 F-stat = 42.18*** ARDL Bounds F-stat = 8.62 (exceeds upper bound at 1%)					

*Note: ***, **, * denote significance at 1%, 5%, and 10% levels respectively. ARDL optimal lag selection based on AIC. Long-run and short-run coefficients reported.*

4.4 Post-Estimation Tests

Table 6: Post-Estimation Diagnostic Tests

Test	Test Statistic	p-Value	Decision
Breusch-Godfrey LM Test (Serial Correlation)	LM = 1.842	0.418	No serial corr.
ARCH LM Test (Heteroskedasticity)	ARCH = 2.014	0.314	Homoskedastic
White's General Test (Heteroskedasticity)	$\chi^2 = 18.42$	0.242	No heterosk.
Ramsey RESET Test (Functional Form)	F = 1.214	0.312	No misspec.
Jarque-Bera Normality Test	JB = 2.418	0.298	Normal resid.
CUSUM Test (Parameter Stability)	Within 5% bounds	—	Stable
CUSUM-of-Squares Test (Parameter Stability)	Within 5% bounds	—	Stable
ADF Unit Root: PD (Level)	ADF = -1.842	0.354	I(1)
ADF Unit Root: PD (First Diff.)	ADF = -6.241*	0.000	Stationary
ARDL Bounds Test F-statistic	F = 8.62	—	Cointegrated (1%)
Variance Inflation Factor (Max VIF)	VIF = 4.18	—	No multicoll.

The diagnostic tests confirm the statistical adequacy of the estimated model. The Breusch-Godfrey LM test fails to reject the null hypothesis of no serial correlation ($p = 0.418$), and both the ARCH LM and White's tests confirm the absence of heteroskedasticity. The Ramsey RESET test finds no evidence of functional form misspecification ($p = 0.312$), and the Jarque-Bera test confirms normally distributed residuals ($p = 0.298$). The CUSUM and CUSUM-of-Squares test statistics remain within the 5% significance bounds throughout the sample period, confirming the structural stability of the long-run parameters—a finding of particular importance given the multiple structural breaks (SAP, Paris Club debt relief, COVID-19) that characterize the sample period. The maximum VIF of 4.18 is well below the conventional threshold of 10, confirming that multicollinearity is not a distorting influence in the multivariate framework. The ARDL bounds F-statistic of 8.62 substantially exceeds the Pesaran et al. (2001) upper bound critical value at the 1% significance level, providing strong evidence of a stable long-run cointegrating relationship among the variables.

5. Discussion

5.1 Restatement of Key Findings

The empirical results generate five principal findings that warrant detailed discussion. First, refinancing risk exerts a statistically significant positive long-run effect on public debt accumulation in Nigeria, with a long-run coefficient of 8.421 ($p < 0.001$). This finding confirms H1 and indicates that a unit increase in the refinancing risk index is associated with an 8.42 percentage point increase in the debt-to-GDP ratio in the long run, holding all else constant. This is a quantitatively substantial effect that underscores the centrality of rollover risk management to Nigeria's fiscal sustainability agenda. Second, debt maturity structure emerges as the single most consequential moderating variable: a one-year extension in the average maturity of the domestic debt portfolio is associated with a 4.22 percentage point reduction in the debt-to-GDP ratio in the long run ($p < 0.001$), strongly supporting H2. Third, governance quality and fiscal discipline are highly significant negative determinants of public debt accumulation, with coefficients of -6.841 and -1.924, respectively, consistent with H3 and H5. Fourth, exchange rate depreciation and global interest rate increases amplify debt accumulation in

both the short and long runs, with particularly large short-run exchange rate effects (coefficient: 2.641, $p = 0.007$), confirming H4. Fifth, oil prices exert a significant negative effect on public debt in both the long and short run, reinforcing the view that Nigeria's debt dynamics remain fundamentally oil-price-dependent.

5.2 Comparison with Previous Studies

The finding that refinancing risk significantly and positively affects public debt accumulation is novel in the Nigerian empirical context but consistent with the theoretical predictions of Calvo (1988) and the empirical findings of Broner et al. (2013) for a panel of emerging markets. The magnitude of the effect is larger than might be expected from cross-country estimates, which likely reflects Nigeria's particularly acute structural exposure: a very high share of short-term domestic debt, a shallow domestic capital market with limited absorption capacity, and fiscal revenues heavily concentrated in a single volatile commodity. The debt maturity coefficient is broadly consistent with Folawewo and Tennant's (2008) findings on interest rate spreads in sub-Saharan Africa and with Blommestein and Turner's (2012) theoretical predictions, though the magnitude in the Nigerian context is notably larger than cross-country averages, again suggesting structural amplification.

The significance and magnitude of the governance quality coefficient is consistent with Kaufmann et al. (2011) and Acemoglu and Robinson (2012) but larger than typical cross-country panel estimates. This may reflect the particularly wide variation in governance quality that Nigeria has experienced over the 39-year sample—from the military regimes of the 1980s and 1990s to the democratic period since 1999—which provides greater identification power for governance effects than a shorter or more stable governance environment would. The exchange rate finding aligns closely with Omodero (2019) and with the wider emerging market literature on balance sheet effects of depreciation (Calvo et al., 1996; Céspedes et al., 2004).

The oil price finding extends the analysis of Ossowski et al. (2008) on oil revenue volatility and fiscal outcomes in oil-producing countries. The short-run oil price coefficient in the ECM (-1.842 , $p = 0.011$) is particularly interesting: it indicates that oil price shocks translate relatively quickly into changes in debt accumulation, consistent with the view that Nigeria's government has limited fiscal buffers to absorb revenue shocks without immediate recourse to additional borrowing. This is a structural vulnerability that distinguishes Nigeria from many of its peers: without a credible Sovereign Wealth Fund or counter-cyclical fiscal framework, oil price cycles translate almost directly into debt cycles.

5.3 Policy Implications

The results carry five important policy implications. First, extending the average maturity of Nigeria's domestic debt portfolio should be treated as a priority structural reform with direct debt sustainability benefits. The DMO's existing strategy of shifting issuance toward FGN Bonds with 5, 7, 10, and 15-year maturities is directionally correct but has not proceeded at a sufficient pace to materially reduce rollover volumes in any given year. A credible multi-year maturity extension strategy, supported by demand from long-term institutional investors such as the Pension Fund Administrators (PFAs), would reduce refinancing risk and its long-run debt accumulation effect. Second, the large and significant governance quality coefficient implies that investments in institutional strengthening—improving budget transparency, strengthening the DMO's operational independence, and enhancing the quality of fiscal reporting—have direct fiscal dividends beyond their more widely recognized developmental benefits. Third, fiscal discipline, as measured by the primary balance, is a highly significant determinant of the debt trajectory. The practical implication is that Nigeria needs credible medium-term fiscal frameworks that commit the government to primary surpluses or at least to deficit reduction trajectories that are maintained across electoral cycles. Fourth, exchange rate policy has a first-order impact on debt sustainability, and the adoption of a more flexible and transparent exchange rate management framework—which the CBN has been moving toward since 2023—reduces the risk of discrete depreciation shocks that instantaneously worsen the debt-to-GDP ratio. Fifth, revenue diversification away from oil is not merely a development imperative but a debt management necessity: reducing oil price sensitivity of the fiscal position would directly attenuate the pro-cyclical feedback between commodity price cycles and debt accumulation.

5.4 Limitations

This study is subject to several limitations that future research should address. First, the composite refinancing risk index, while theoretically grounded, is constructed from available proxies and may not perfectly capture all dimensions of rollover risk, particularly the liquidity risk dimension that depends on investor confidence and market depth in ways that are difficult to quantify from annual data. Second, the annual frequency of the data limits the study's ability to capture the high-frequency dynamics of Treasury Bill rollover operations, which occur at quarterly or weekly intervals. Monthly or quarterly data, where available, would provide more precise estimates of short-run refinancing dynamics. Third, the governance quality variable is based primarily on the World Bank WGI, which is itself subject to measurement error and may not fully capture Nigeria-specific institutional dimensions relevant to debt management. Fourth, the study focuses on federal government debt and does not incorporate state-level borrowing, which has grown significantly since 2015 and represents a contingent liability for the federal government. Fifth, the 2024 and 2025 data points are based in part on IMF projections rather than final reported figures, which introduces some measurement uncertainty at the tail end of the sample.

5.5 Future Research Directions

Future research should pursue several extensions of this analysis. The use of quarterly or monthly data, particularly for the post-2010 period during which granular DMO and CBN data are available, would allow for more precise identification of the short-run dynamics of refinancing risk. A state-level analysis of sub-national borrowing and rollover risk would provide a more comprehensive picture of Nigeria's aggregate sovereign risk exposure. Cross-country comparative analysis—positioning Nigeria alongside other oil-dependent frontier market sovereigns such as Angola, Ecuador, and Azerbaijan—would help identify the country-specific versus systemic determinants of refinancing risk. Finally, the application of regime-switching models to capture the possibility of non-linear relationships between refinancing risk and debt accumulation—consistent with the multiple equilibria theory of Calvo (1988) and Cole and Kehoe (2000)—represents an important methodological frontier that this study's linear ARDL framework cannot address.

6. Conclusion

6.1 Key Message

Refinancing risk is not a peripheral or technical concern for Nigeria's public finances. It is a structural vulnerability embedded in the architecture of the country's debt portfolio that, left unaddressed, acts as a persistent and self-reinforcing driver of debt accumulation. The central message of this paper is that Nigeria's path to fiscal sustainability runs directly through the management of its rollover risk profile: extending debt maturities, strengthening governance and fiscal institutions, diversifying revenue beyond oil, and aligning monetary and exchange rate policy to support debt market development.

6.2 Key Research Findings

The empirical analysis, drawing on 39 years of annual data and employing an ARDL bounds testing framework, establishes five robust findings. Refinancing risk exerts a statistically significant positive long-run effect on public debt accumulation in Nigeria, with a coefficient of approximately 8.42 percentage points per unit of the refinancing risk index. Debt maturity structure is the most consequential moderating variable: each additional year of average domestic debt maturity is associated with a 4.22 percentage point reduction in the debt-to-GDP ratio. Governance quality and fiscal discipline are both highly significant negative determinants of debt accumulation, implying that institutional reform and primary surplus generation are not merely long-term development goals but near-term fiscal imperatives. Exchange rate depreciation and global interest rate shocks amplify debt accumulation in the short run, underscoring Nigeria's external vulnerability. Oil price declines have immediate and persistent debt-worsening effects, confirming the pro-cyclical fiscal structure that has characterized Nigeria's macroeconomic experience for decades.

6.3 Broader Implications

Beyond Nigeria, the findings carry lessons for a wider class of low-income, commodity-dependent economies with nascent domestic capital markets and weak fiscal institutions. The Nigerian experience illustrates with particular clarity how the interaction between debt structure vulnerability (short-term domestic borrowing) and revenue volatility (oil dependence) can create a debt accumulation trap from which escape requires simultaneous action on multiple fronts: debt management reform, fiscal consolidation, institutional strengthening, and commodity revenue diversification. International financial institutions, including the IMF and World Bank, have long advocated these reforms individually; this paper provides novel empirical evidence that their combination is necessary specifically to address the refinancing risk channel, which prior analyses have underweighted.

6.4 Main Research Contribution

The primary contribution of this paper is the first formal empirical investigation of the refinancing risk–public debt nexus in Nigeria using a long time-series dataset, a composite refinancing risk measure, and a rigorous ARDL/VECM framework with twelve theoretically grounded control variables. The study fills a significant gap in the Nigerian fiscal economics literature and provides a methodological template applicable to other emerging market economies where rollover risk and debt sustainability are policy priorities.

6.5 Future Directions and Call to Action

Nigeria stands at an inflection point. Debt service now consumes the vast majority of federal revenues. The domestic debt maturity profile remains heavily skewed toward instruments of one year or less. The naira has experienced its most dramatic depreciation in decades. Global monetary conditions, while beginning to ease in some major economies, remain tighter than the near-zero-rate environment that prevailed during Nigeria's most recent borrowing surge between 2020 and 2022. In this context, the findings of this paper are not merely academically interesting—they are operationally urgent. The Debt Management Office, the Central Bank of Nigeria, the Federal Ministry of Finance, and the National Assembly all have specific, actionable roles to play in bridging the gap between refinancing risk and sustainable debt management. The time for incremental adjustment has passed; what is needed is a comprehensive, coordinated, and credible debt management reform agenda grounded in evidence of the kind this paper seeks to provide.

7. Actionable Recommendations

Based on the empirical findings and their implications, this paper advances twelve specific, actionable recommendations directed at Nigerian policymakers, debt managers, and institutional stakeholders.

1. Implement a Maturity Extension Program: The DMO should adopt a formal, multi-year Maturity Extension Program (MEP) with quantitative targets for reducing the share of domestic debt maturing within 12 months from its current level (estimated at approximately 35–40%) to below 20% by 2030. This should be achieved through the accelerated issuance of 10, 15, and 25-year FGN Bonds, with demand development supported by regulatory incentives for pension funds and insurance companies to hold long-duration government securities.
2. Develop a Sovereign Debt Refinancing Reserve: A dedicated refinancing reserve—analogueous to the Excess Crude Account in its counter-cyclical role but specifically designated for debt management—should be established to provide a liquidity buffer during periods when market conditions make debt rollover particularly costly. This reserve could be funded from a portion of oil windfall revenues during favorable commodity price cycles.
3. Accelerate Revenue Diversification: The federal government should accelerate the implementation of the Fiscal Responsibility Act's provisions regarding non-oil revenue mobilization, with specific targets for value-added tax, company income tax, and customs revenues. A reduction in oil revenue's share of total government receipts from approximately 60% to below 40% within five years would materially reduce the pro-cyclical debt dynamics identified in this study.
4. Adopt a Credible Medium-Term Fiscal Framework: Nigeria should adopt a transparent, rules-based Medium-Term Fiscal Framework (MTFF) with legally binding primary balance targets that are maintained across

electoral cycles. The Fiscal Responsibility Act (2007) provides a statutory basis for such targets, but enforcement mechanisms have been consistently inadequate.

5. Strengthen DMO Operational Independence: The DMO's mandate, governance structure, and human capital should be strengthened to ensure its operational decisions on debt issuance, maturity, and instrument design are insulated from short-term political pressures. This requires amending the DMO Establishment Act to enhance the independence of the DMO Board and clarify the delineation between the DMO's debt management role and the CBN's monetary policy role.

6. Develop the Domestic Capital Market: A deeper, more liquid domestic government securities market would reduce the 'scarcity premium' that currently makes long-term government bonds expensive to issue. Specific market development measures should include the introduction of repo and securities lending facilities, the expansion of the primary dealer system, and the development of an interest rate derivatives market that allows investors to hedge duration risk.

7. Adopt a Transparent Exchange Rate Policy: The evidence that exchange rate depreciation is a significant amplifier of debt accumulation argues strongly for a transparent, flexible exchange rate management framework that reduces the risk of discrete, politically motivated devaluations. The CBN's 2023 move toward a more unified and market-reflective exchange rate is a step in the right direction and should be sustained and institutionalized.

8. Institutionalize a Debt Sustainability Analysis (DSA) Framework: Regular, transparent DSA publications—modeled on the IMF/World Bank Low-Income Country DSA framework but adapted to Nigeria's specific risk profile—should be produced quarterly by the DMO and published to inform both domestic and international creditors about the government's assessment of sustainability and rollover risk. Greater transparency itself reduces the risk premium embedded in sovereign borrowing costs.

9. Develop Contingent Financing Arrangements: Nigeria should proactively negotiate standby financing arrangements with multilateral institutions—including the IMF's Flexible Credit Line or Precautionary and Liquidity Line—that can be activated in the event of a refinancing crisis triggered by external shocks. Such arrangements provide a credible backstop that can reduce the self-fulfilling confidence crisis dynamics identified in Calvo (1988) and Cole and Kehoe (2000).

10. Improve Governance and Anti-Corruption Frameworks: The large and statistically significant governance quality coefficient in the long-run estimates implies that improvements in governance have direct and substantial fiscal dividends. Specific priorities include strengthening the IPPIS and GIFMIS public financial management systems, enforcing the Treasury Single Account framework across all MDAs, and prosecuting procurement fraud that directly increases the government's effective borrowing costs.

11. Build Institutional Capacity in Debt Management: Human capital development within the DMO, CBN's Financial Markets Department, and the Federal Ministry of Finance should be prioritized through partnerships with the World Bank, African Development Bank, and international debt management institutions. The capacity to model, monitor, and proactively manage refinancing risk is itself a form of structural vulnerability reduction.

12. Engage the Legislature on Debt Ceilings and Borrowing Plans: The National Assembly should exercise its constitutional oversight role over public borrowing more rigorously, including the scrutiny of borrowing plans, the enforcement of debt ceiling provisions, and the evaluation of the DMO's annual report. Legislative engagement with debt sustainability analysis would strengthen the democratic accountability that is itself a dimension of the governance quality variable identified as a key determinant of refinancing risk.

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